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# California Grocery Stores Could See Major Change Under New Bill

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A new bill introduced by California lawmakers would require grocery stores across the state to prominently display foods that are not considered ultra-processed, making it easier for shoppers to identify what supporters describe as healthier options, according to multiple outlets, including KQED and Politico.

What Is California's New Bill

The new bill, introduced by Democratic Assembly member Jesse Gabriel, would create a first-in-the-nation "California Certified" label for food products that meet the state's definition of non-ultra-processed.

If the bill is passed, according to Politico, to earn the "California Certified" seal, food manufacturers would need to apply through accredited third-party certifiers, similar to the USDA Organic program. Certification would open in 2028 and would require renewal every three years. Companies would pay certification costs, while retailers meeting certain sales thresholds would be obligated to give certified products prominent shelf placement.

Retailers would then be required to feature qualifying "California Certified" labeled products in high-visibility areas such as aisle ends, checkout lanes, or store entrances.

The goal, supporters say, is not to ban products but to give consumers clearer guidance inside stores where the amount of products available can make decisions overwhelming and confusing. Gabriel told Politico that the state should address ultraprocessed food in grocery stores, but in a way that "strengthens consumer choice and encourages innovation."

What Are Ultra-Processed Foods?

Under a new California law—passed last year—ultra-processed foods are defined as products that contain certain additives — such as artificial flavors, colors, emulsifiers, or stabilizers — and are also high in added sugar, sodium, or saturated fat. That definition—first used to restrict ultra-processed foods in school meals—underpins the newly proposed grocery-store labeling system.

Why Is California Pushing This Ultra-Processed Food Labeling?

Supporters of the bill argue that the new system will address widespread consumer confusion about nutrition labeling and ingredient lists. Politico reported that Bernadette Del Chiaro—who has helped Gabriel on previous ultraprocessed food-related bills—said there are a lot of "manufacturers that make claims about their products that aren't necessarily all that clarifying for consumers."

The certification seal, she said, is designed to function as a simple visual cue rather than a mandate on what consumers can buy: "The beauty of this idea is the label will absolutely say 'not ultraprocessed,' it will be a beacon for consumers."

What The Critics Say

The proposal has drawn skepticism from some critics, who note that although California law includes its own definition, there is no single, universally accepted definition of "ultra-processed" food. They argue that slapping a label onto a product could oversimplify complex nutrition science. KQED reports that concerns have also been raised about whether consumers might misinterpret the label as an overall measure of how healthy a product is,

when it's just focusing on how a food is produced and the additives it contains.

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